Three Kingdoms Period

The Three Kingdoms Period occurred between 57 BCE and 668 CE. Although originally there were only three kingdoms, a fourth “state” named Gaya had gained power by this time. Silla, Goguryeo, Baekje and Gaya were competing to gain ultimate dominion. In the Historical Records of the Three Kingdoms, also known as the Samguksagi, it is stated that these clashes began during the first century BCE. However, archaeologists generally agree they began during the second or third centuries CE. Some scholars suggest a later date when the states began showing signs of a more central government.

The capital of Goguryeo was located at Pyongyang, which is the capital of modern day North Korea. It began to prosper during the fifth century CE under the ruler Gwanggaeto the Great (391 – 413 CE). Goguryeo expanded its borders and seized parts of the northern peninsula known as Manchuria, which is located in modern day Mongolia and northeast China.

At the same time Silla was being ruled by King Beopheung (r. 514 – 540 CE) and his capital was located at Kumsong or modern day Gyeongjo. His government was much more organized and structured than Gwanggaeto’s. He often emphasized the need for agriculture with his ministers. Eventually, he was able to establish a sophisticated irrigation system, which included the usage of primitive ploughs.

Gaya, on the other hand, did not develop into a structured kingdom. The famous Pon Kaya was the capital of Gaya and located between two powerful states. Being situated near two powerful armies did not help as it was eventually conquered by Silla in 532 CE.

During the fourth century BCE, the state of Baekje prospered under the leadership of King Kunchogo. He founded his capital at Hansong or contemporary Gwangju and eventually formed an alliance with the kingdom of Silla. From 433 and 553 CE, Baekje and Silla enjoyed a relatively peaceful relationship with each other. However in 554 CE, a battle between the two kingdoms broke out at the Kwansan-song Fortress in